

sent SMSes portraying Aarushi as a sexually active teenager. Politicians have argued that the Talwars should sue the Noida police for defamation. In all this, a bright focussed teenager, who veered between wanting to become a doctor like her parents and a dancer like her 21-year-old instructor Aradhana Khanna—who gave her gang of girls the name Awesome Foursome—has been forgotten.

Who was Aarushi? By all accounts she was a special girl, born to her parents after five years of marriage and fertility treatments at Delhi's Sir Ganga Ram Hospital. Her parents had met at Delhi's Maulana Azad Medical College as undergraduates, he the son of a well-connected cardiac surgeon, J.R. Talwar, and she the daughter of an air force officer D.B. Chitnis. Aarushi, born in 1994, led to several changes in their lifestyle. They moved to Noida, the well-heeled Jalvayu Vihar, to be near Nupur's mother, Lata, who was given the charge of looking after Aarushi till 7.30 p.m. everyday. Her school was within shouting distance, her tuitions, two a day during the weekdays, were also close by and every demand was duly satisfied, whether it was a holiday in Singapore (taken in 2006) or sleepovers with friends, a camera for her 14th birthday or an elaborate Britney Spears make-up set from her father, when he went on a trip to the US.

For Vidushi Durrani, a Class X student of DPS Noida, daughter of the Durrani, Talwars' closest friends, and part of Aarushi's girl gang, her friend was just beginning to blossom. She had started reading seriously, perhaps influenced by Fiza—her friends recall seeing Chetan Bhagat's latest book, *The 3 Mistakes of My Life*, face down on her desk. "We used to keep telling her to stand up to bullies," says Vidushi, who had a rather bizarre experience online, when

one of her Orkut conversations with Aarushi before her death, which ended with her saying, presumably playfully that she was going to kill her, ("stupid gal....did i fill dat scrap entry....i don even knw ur password! lemme c u...i'll kill u!") was misinterpreted as evidence of her guilt. As for her boyfriend, a Class X student of DPS, Noida, Anmol Agarwal, he has removed Aarushi's picture from his Orkut album and after a 10-hour interrogation by the police in the absence of his parents, which put an unfortunate spin on their 688

centred around Aarushi, with friends or family who had children to keep her company (which may be one reason why every home video taken on recent holidays features the Durrani, whom, the Noida police alleged, were part of a murky wife-swapping club that included the Talwars). "I remember Rajesh calling her from a GAP store during a trip to the US, asking her to describe the kind of jeans she wanted him to buy," recalls Nupur, sitting in her mother's home.

Nupur remembers her

Noida POLICE version

The Noida police suspected the involvement of insiders as there seemed to be no forced entry. According to their theory, Talwar allegedly killed both, Aarushi and Hemraj, because they were aware of his extra-marital affair. While Aarushi objected to her father's affair, Hemraj decided to blackmail him. Talwar allegedly killed Hemraj first on the terrace and then came down to kill Aarushi in a drunken state.

What the CBI says

There was no evidence against Talwar, according to the case diary, at the time of his arrest. Even the forensic evidence gathered so far does not indicate anything about Talwar's involvement. Instead, investigations reveal that it was his compounder Krishna, Vijay Mandal, a help employed by Talwar's neighbour, and Rajkumar, Durrani's domestic help, who killed Aarushi and Hemraj under the influence of alcohol.

CRITICAL conversations

A few days before Talwar's arrest, senior Noida police officers confirmed that the family's phone lines were tapped. Did these conversations form the basis of his arrest? If so, what do they say?

calls over 45 days, has steered clear of the case. He declined to be interviewed for the article.

Aarushi was a girl who liked to win. As she wrote in one of her holiday homework assignments, "Class VI was a difficult year. I came down from 92 per cent to 89 per cent and that made me feel bad. But I knew I had to do well." Her exams saw her mother taking time off from her work, to be with her daughter. Their holidays

preparing a questionnaire for the school's I Decide club, a day before she was killed. When she volunteered to help, Aarushi cut her short saying: "I don't want your views. I have my own." Strong-minded but, as her dance instructor Khanna recalls, also the quietest of the group. "The other three would chatter away telling me all the gossip. She would smile and listen. There was an innocence about her that was disarming."

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TWIN TALK:
Gurdarshan Singh
(top) and
Arun Kumar